

Facebook to the rescue

It is estimated that about 70 per cent of local businesses in US are moving to Facebook for their marketing activities

Marching towards Chrome OS

In its attempt to offer a web only based OS Google has upgraded the file handling and file sharing capabilities of Google Docs

remains the quality of answers provided, once again placing experts on one side of the fence, and the perplexed masses on the other.

While the challenges faced by newest start-ups are difficult, the web and its users are continually evolving, and taking advantage of these changes is certainly one of the healthy ways of not just surviving, but thriving.

Quora, one of the newer start-ups in the field, is a knowledge market or Q&A web site that opened its virtual doors to the public in June 2010. It describes itself as a “continually improving collection of questions and answers created, edited, and organized by everyone who uses it.” Its name, the plural of Quorum, is a description in itself – meaning the minimum number of people of deliberative body required to conduct business in that group, or in this case, groups.

One of its primary differen-



tiators is that it takes into consideration the fast-evolving attitude people are developing towards identity on the internet, which is quickly trending away from anonymity and ‘pseudonymity’ towards real comfort with real names. This is a mark of a maturing web culture, triggered in no small part by the growing prevalence of personal blogs, as well as social and

In Quora's words...

Everything on Quora is tied back to a person. Each question and answer has a revision history associated with it, and each change in the log is associated with the person who made

it. People use their real names and pictures on Quora and have a short bio describing who they are; this helps anyone reading things they write to understand why they should believe what is written and take into account

the author's perspective. For example, if Michael Jordan gives an answer to a question about basketball, that means something really different from someone who has never played the game giving an answer. **[d]**

professional networking sites like Facebook, Twitter, and LinkedIn.

Quora asks its members to use their real names and real professions on the site. Utilizing such a mature web-practice certainly has its benefits on a Q&A web site; however, careful consideration of the answer itself will always be essential, regardless of the identity of the answerer. While one's answer or opinion on an issue can be given more appropriate credence, it should not mean that the substance of the reply is disregarded on the basis on non-relevant credentials. Sur-

no proof to establish its users' identities and professions. This places a level of trust in users that still might be premature by present web-culture standards, and only those users with obvious aliases are blocked by the web site, pending submission of proof. There have also been cases where people with unconventional names (unconventional with respect to the western world) have been blocked on suspicion of fraudulent identity. Understandably, these individuals were not happy with these apparent double standards when it came to identity verification. Many users have admittedly tried and succeeded in faking their profession, going from chef to exotic dancer, without repercussion.

This new challenge, of assuming identities and professions, necessarily not celebrity in nature but fictitious none the less, might just be as difficult to overcome as the first lot of challenges. However, the small team at work behind the scenes at Quora is certainly aware of these flaws in the system, and workarounds do seem to be around the corner.

Apart from Quora, numerous other Q&A start-ups are popping up, such as Stack Exchange – a network of specialised Q&A sites; and Hipster – a yet to be launched location based Q&A site. Joel Spolsky, one of the founders of Stack Exchange, speaks of the market that new

Q&A services serve – providing the information that doesn't yet exist on the internet, information that cannot be web searched. This ranges from opinions to factual knowledge, and everything in between.

Stack Exchange, an aggregator, also keeps its community tightly knit and maintains quality by trying to build new Q&A sites in “overlapping circles.”

The rising trend of Q&A sites is making an impact elsewhere as well, with mega-sites such as Facebook planning to introduce Q&A and knowledge market features to its own interface in the near future.

The potential for advertising on these Q&A sites, especially specialised ones that attract a niche audience, is also quickly becoming an enticing prospect for many companies, who can now reach a target demographic of educated and savvy individuals, without expending valuable resources on a broad-spectrum of potential consumers. The meanest trick of course, would be for a knowledge marketplace to balance itself on that fine line of mass between

While there has not been a shortage of internet-based knowledge marketplaces, no matter how specialised, in nearly a decade, the future looks capable of offering new ways to find the answers and opinions you are looking for, from real people. **[d]**